

Empowering Families: Navigating Autism Support in Postsecondary Education:



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OBJECTIVES

Understand the difference in eligibility requirements and support provision between PSE programs and ASP programs.

Understand the resources and support available to help navigate the college search.

Essential Question: What are the key differences in eligibility requirements between the two types of programs and where can I learn more about either option?

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Ran a college program for students with intellectual disability.

Teaches special education preservice teachers.

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AGENDA

- Review the rationale.
- Provide an overview of postsecondary education (PSE) programs for students with intellectual disability and key resources from Think College.
- Provide an overview of Autism Specific Programs (ASPs) and key resources from the College Autism Network.
- Review common considerations from the perspective of each type of program.
- Answer your questions on eligibility and the college search process.

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RATIONALE

- Confusion amongst prospective students and families.
- Reducing the amount of questions around which program students are eligible for.

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Postsecondary Education (PSE) Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability



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What is Think College?

Two national centers: National Coordinating Center and the Inclusive Higher Education Network

Expanding opportunities and access to higher education for students with intellectual disability

Working to build capacity amongst family members, prospective students, and K-12 educators to ensure that students who want to go to college know it's a option and how to best prepare!

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Characteristics of PSE Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability

Created for and support students with intellectual disability

Traditionally non-degree, auditing, using modifications

Ran by and housed within a college or university

Provide a meaningful credential and often access to industry credentials

Different entrance criteria/process. No SAT/GPA.

Support models, course offerings, and level of inclusivity can vary significantly.

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Postsecondary Education Programs



College Course Engagement



Internships/Works Study



Paid Jobs (on/off campus)



Campus Life/Organizations



Living Independently

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Why is college important for people with intellectual disability?

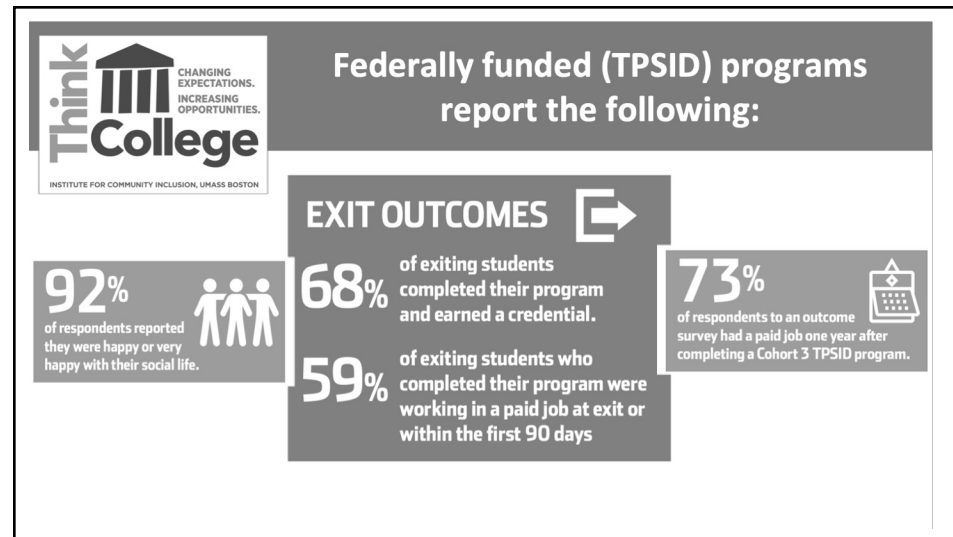
In 2022, there were more than 420,000 school age students with intellectual disability in the United States. Fewer than 2% are likely to attend college after high school.

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What are the outcomes for that 98%?

- Only 15% have paid employment in the community
- 42% attend a day program or sheltered workshop
- 44% report they often or sometimes feel lonely
 - 29.3% live below the poverty line

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Intellectual Disability

The Higher Education Opportunity Act, in Section § 668.231, defines a student with an intellectual disability. The term "student with an intellectual disability" means a student— (A) with a cognitive impairment, characterized by significant limitations in— (i) intellectual and cognitive functioning; and (ii) adaptive behavior as expressed in conceptual, social, and practical adaptive skills; and (B) who is currently, or was formerly, eligible for a free appropriate public education under the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act [20 U.S.C. 1400 et seq.].

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Intellectual Disability

DOCUMENTATION

- (1) A documented comprehensive and individualized psycho-educational evaluation and diagnosis of an intellectual disability by a psychologist or other qualified professional; or
- (2) A record of the disability from a local or State educational agency, or government agency, such as the Social Security Administration or a vocational rehabilitation agency, that identifies the intellectual disability.

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Intellectual Disability

Some programs will accept students without an actual diagnosis/ classification of intellectual disability, but usually require that a students' support needs are reflective of their other program participants.

Some (most) are very strict in adhering to the law and intention of why these programs were created.

For those programs who have received US Dept of Education approval to offer federal financial aid for non-degree programs, only those students with a documented intellectual disability can receive that aid.

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What about students with autism?

If a student with autism also has a co-occurring documented intellectual disability (significant cognitive impairment with significant limitation in cognitive functioning, and limitations in adaptive behavior, and who was formerly or currently eligible for IDEA services), that student DOES meet the definition of an eligible student with an intellectual disability.

If a student with autism does not have a co-occurring, documented intellectual disability..., that student does NOT meet the definition of an eligible student for financial aid.

Programs supported by Think College are usually not a good fit for students with autism, who would like to obtain a college degree- that's why our friends from the College Autism Network are here!

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Eligibility Requirements

Think College Guiding Principles and Accreditation Standards: Eligibility requirements should not be so high that access is exclusive to only students with lower support needs.

Requirements/admissions processes vary from program to program.

Do students: (1) Want to work towards more independence, (2) connect college attendance to desired outcomes, (3) communicate their needs, demonstrate general safety and decision-making skills?

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Entrance Process

Application

Interview

Orientation

FDOC!

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The only national database of college programs for students with intellectual disability.





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Autism Specific Programs



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Types of Programs and Services

- Autism-Specific Programs (ASPs)
- Enhanced services within a Disability Services setting
- Referrals to outside providers



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Autism Specific Programs

- For matriculating (enrolled in degree-granting program) students
- May have additional fee
- Student willingness to participate is key
- Provide support services such as tutoring, social activities, executive function coaching
- Do not provide personal care assistants, modifications to curricular or behavioral standards
- May focus on first year, or provide different levels of support for all years
- Often provide a special orientation program



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Enhanced Services

- Disability Services or Resources Office
- One or more professionals conversant in autism and neurodivergence
- Might offer autism-specific opportunities like social groups, peer mentoring, less likely to be “cohort-based” like an ASP
- Might charge a fee
- May include a special summer orientation program



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Referrals and Partnerships with Outside Providers

- College or university does not provide enhanced services but has relationships with outside providers like Executive Functioning coaches
- Contract is between student/family and outside provider



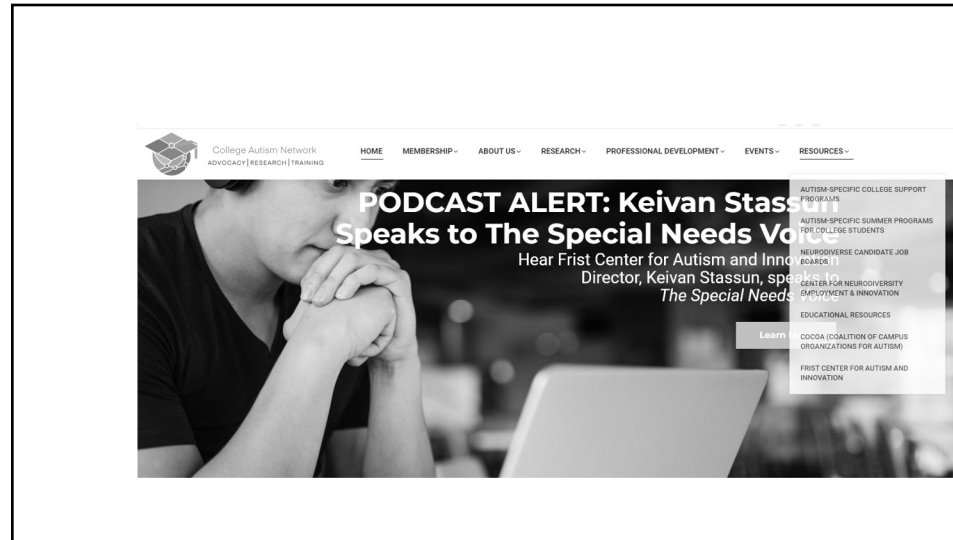
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Students should be able to...

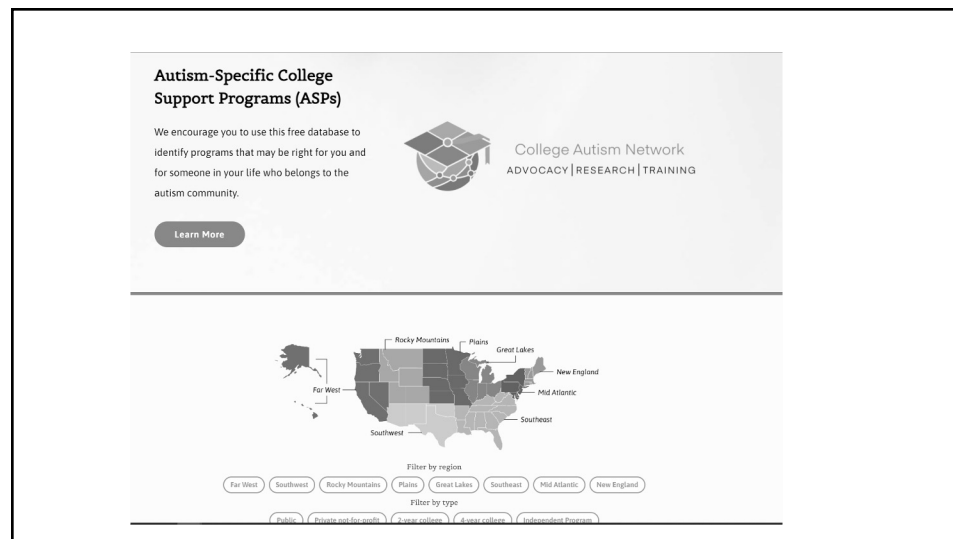
- Wake up on their own, and manage activities of daily living, including:
- Reliably manage any medication needs
- Be able to articulate strategies that have helped in the past
- Manage their schedule (including appointments with campus staff)
- Do college-level academic work (with some tutoring if needed)
- Recognize potentially dangerous situations (i.e., excessive substance use, sexual activities, vulnerability to crime)



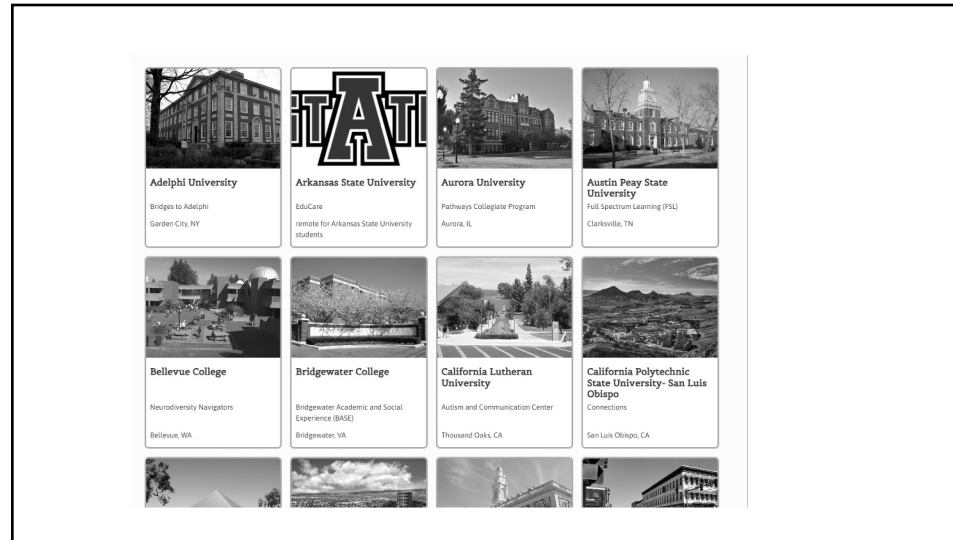
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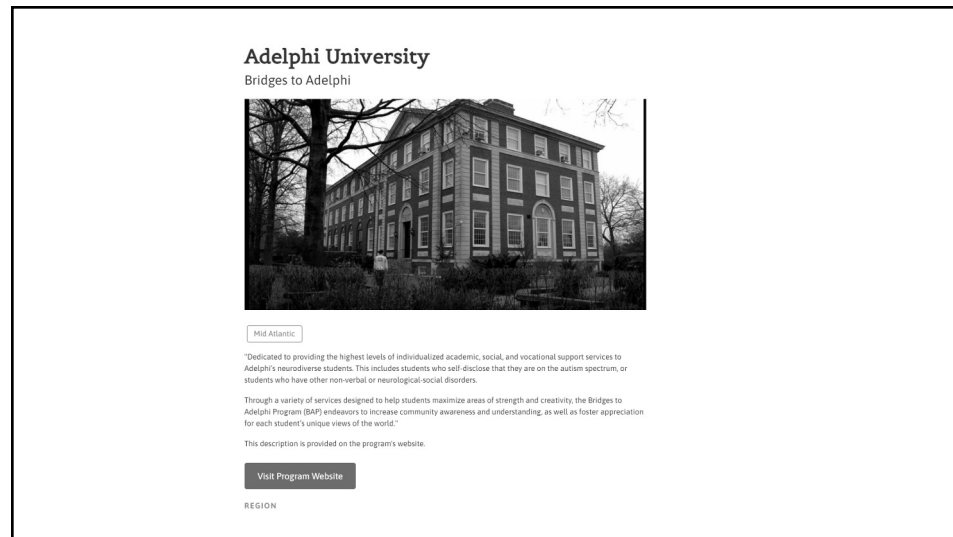
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Common Considerations

In this segment, we will address five common considerations our respective organizations and programs are asked about frequently. Please feel free to pose your own questions in the Q&A!

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What are the roles of parents?

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How do programs handle sharing information and disability disclosure?

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What is the difference between accommodations and modifications and are they used in both types of programs?

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What do programs guarantee in terms of access and success?

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What about campuses where both types of programs exist- do they
work together?

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What questions do YOU have?



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